

Ending Well

How a thing ends decides what you carry into what comes next. Twelve weeks of Breaking Free are ending. Before you close it, say what is different, what it cost, what you saw along the way, what God did, and what you are taking with you — in your own words, one line at a time. Each line starts for you; you finish it.

This sheet carries the same questions as the page, for working away from a screen. When you are ready, type your lines into Ending Well in Week 12 so it is saved to your page.

Part 1 of 8 — The Doorway

Week 12 says “look for, pray for, and actively seek relationship and community with other men.” This is written to them, before you have met them.

Twelve weeks are done. Start with the men you will walk with. One word for what you feel toward them now — the row has some — then why, in a few words.

Finish the line. For example: To the men I will walk with, I am tired and hopeful. You haven't heard any of this yet. Here it is.

Words to choose from: thankful · grateful · sad · still struggling with · hopeful

To the men I will walk with, I am ...

Name the gold you will look for in the men you find. One thing, said plainly.

Finish the line. For example: What I will look for in you is men who tell the truth before it is safe to.

Words to choose from: courage · honesty · steadiness · patience · mercy · humor · faith · the way you listened

What I will look for in you is ...

Part 2 of 8 — Where I started

Start where you started. Three lines, and a picture a man could see.

Go back to the first week. Where were you — the place, the time of day, what was going on at home? A picture, not a label.

Finish the line. For example: When I started, I was sitting in the truck in the driveway, not ready to go in the house.

When I started, I was ...

Now the sentence you were living on then — the one you said to yourself to get through the day. “I’ve got it handled.” “Nobody needs to know.” Short.

Finish the line. For example: What I told myself was that I had it handled.

What I told myself was ...

And the part of it no one could see from outside.

Finish the line. For example: What nobody knew was how long it had been going on.

What nobody knew was ...

Part 3 of 8 — What changed

Time didn’t change you. The work you did, with nobody watching, did. Say what is different, in three places: body, soul, spirit.

Week 1 called it your Sphere of Influence: “any sound, sight, smell, or touch, you control.” And: “The enemy has had free rein inside your SOI, and he’s been bringing his trash in with him.” What was coming in?

Finish the line. For example: What came in through my eyes and ears was a screen at midnight and voices telling me I was the only one.

What came in through my eyes and ears was ...

The same eyes and ears. Now you are the gatekeeper for what comes in. What do you let in — a first thing in the morning, a habit that has held, a practice you took up? Pick from the row, or write your own.

Finish the line. For example: What I take in now is a walk before the house wakes up and a chapter of John read out loud.

Words to choose from: meditation · prayer · fasting · study · simplicity · solitude · submission · service · confession · worship · guidance · celebration *From Richard Foster’s Celebration of Discipline. Walk With Me teaches all twelve.*

What I take in now is ...

Pick where it is happening, then say what is new there.

Finish the line. For example: What is being renewed in me is how I see my father — the word used to mean absence.

Words to choose from: how I name what I feel · how I see my father · how I see my wife · how I see my kids · how I see other men · how I see myself · what I do with silence · what I call a win · what I do first in the morning

What is being renewed in me is ...

Spirit is where you and God meet. Of faith, hope and love, which one grew — and what does it look like in an ordinary week?

Finish the line. For example: Between me and God, what is growing is hope. I expect him to show up now.

Words to choose from: faith · hope · love

Between me and God, what is growing is ...

Part 4 of 8 — Between the lines

Two of your lines. What happened between them?

Then: *When I started, I was ...* Now: *What I take in now is ...*

A day, a place, something said or done. One or two sentences; the row has some ways to start.

In your words. For example: What happened next was a week I almost skipped, and didn't.

Words to choose from: What happened next was · While that was going on, · Around the same time, · It took weeks, but

Part 5 of 8 — What God did

I will turn their mourning into joy; I will comfort them, and give them gladness for sorrow. — Jeremiah 31:13

If it is still quiet and the struggle is still here, say that. It is not failure. This takes years, not weeks, and God's answer may be as small as twelve weeks kept with nobody watching.

Twelve weeks with no room and no men. What did you notice about yourself that nobody else was there to see? One picture.

Finish the line. For example: Nobody was watching, and what I noticed was that I kept opening the book on the days I wanted to quit.

Nobody was watching, and what I noticed was ...

Before you started — what did you expect of yourself?

Finish the line. For example: What I expected was to quit by week three.

What I expected was ...

What happened. Say it plainly; it is the part a man needs to hear.

Finish the line. For example: What happened instead was I am here, writing this.

What happened instead was ...

What did you ask God for at the start? Say it the way you said it then. Not every ask is answered yet.

Finish the line. For example: I asked him for it to stop.

I asked him for ...

You asked him for: *I asked him for ...* (your line above)

Say what he did, not what you did. For some men it is this: twelve weeks kept with nobody watching, and what got named in them. If nothing has moved yet, say that — it is true, and it belongs here.

Finish the line. For example: What God did was keep me at it for twelve weeks with nobody watching.

What God did was ...

Part 6 of 8 — Between the lines

Two more pairs of your lines. What happened between each?

Hidden: *What nobody knew was ...* Seen: *Nobody was watching, and what I noticed was ...*

The thing nobody knew, and what you noticed with nobody watching. What happened in between — a day, a place, something said or done?

In your words. For example: It took weeks, but one night I said it out loud before I could talk myself out of it.

Words to choose from: What happened next was · While that was going on, · Around the same time, · It took weeks, but

Asked: *I asked him for ...* Answered: *What God did was ...*

What you asked him for, and what he did. How long did it take, and what did the waiting look like?

In your words. For example: While that was going on, I kept asking, and for a month nothing changed except that I kept showing up.

Words to choose from: What happened next was · While that was going on, · Around the same time, · It took weeks, but

Part 7 of 8 — What I take with me

Jesus turned and saw them following and said to them, “What are you seeking?” — John 1:38

His first question to the men who followed him. Answer it for a year from now.

A year down the trail — what do you want to be true? Say it as a man who means to get there.

Finish the line. For example: My hope for the future is to be a man my kids can tell the truth to.

My hope for the future is ...

An ending is a loss, even a good one — a routine, a book open every day. Say what aches. It is holy ground, not weakness.

Finish the line. For example: What I will miss is the hour every day that was only this.

What I will miss is ...

The course is done. What will you need from the men you find?

Finish the line. For example: What I will ask of you is to ask me the question, even when I say I'm fine.

What I will ask of you is ...

Say it plainly and own it. Both are honorable.

Finish the line. For example: Going forward, I will find a group of men and tell them what I wrote here.

Words to choose from: find men · keep walking on my own for now

Going forward, I will ...

Not the whole life. One small thing, repeated, that moves you one degree — something you could start tomorrow.

Finish the line. For example: The one small thing I will try this month is finding one man and telling him I did this.

The one small thing I will try this month is ...

How will you know? Something you could see or count, four weeks from now.

Finish the line. For example: I'll know it has held when it is still happening four weeks from now.

I'll know it has held when ...

Name the sign before it comes — what you will be doing, and what you will be feeling. Pick from the rows, or write your own.

Finish the line. For example: I'll know I've drifted when my phone goes quiet and I tell myself I'm fine.

Words to choose from: a missed week · a quiet phone · a bad night · "I'm fine" · the old screen · a long silence

I'll know I've drifted when ...

Not a name — the words. What does it say?

Finish the line. For example: The voice that calls me back says, “They heard the worst and stayed.”

Words to choose from: “You’re not alone in this.” · “Come back.” · “Do the next right thing.” · “They heard the worst and stayed.”

The voice that calls me back says ...

Week 12: “The days are not the achievement. Whatever you did that made the days is the achievement. Find it, name it out loud in the room, and do it again.” Pick one, or write your own.

Finish the line. For example: I will answer it by reading this again, that day.

Words to choose from: reading this again · a text to one man · coffee with one man · a meeting

I will answer it by ...

Part 8 of 8 — Set a stone

When your children ask in time to come, ‘What do those stones mean to you?’ then you shall tell them... So these stones shall be to the people of Israel a memorial forever. — Joshua 4:6–7

Israel set twelve stones at the Jordan so that when their children asked “What do those stones mean to you?” there would be an answer. A stone is set to be found again — by you, and by whoever asks. Choose yours: one of your own lines above, or the words you walk by.

Or your own words.

Your own words. For example: Do the next right thing.

Naming well is a skill. Name the one this is for, and you will name other things well too.

Finish the line. For example: This stone is for my son, for when he asks.

Words to choose from: my son · my daughter · my wife · a friend · a man I walk with · my group · the man I was · myself, a year from now · someone who will ask one day

This stone is for ...

Pick one to see where it comes from, or write your own.

Finish the line. For example: What this stone means to me is a new discipline: I do the next right thing.

Words to choose from: a rescue · a new discipline · more hope · growth in faith · capacity to love · a sacrifice

What this stone means to me is ...

On the page you can tap one of your own lines from What God did instead. Three months after you set it, we will ask you what it means to you.

Written at the end of Breaking Free. · ancientpathcoaching.com